REDCOAT EQUIPMENT

A British soldier's most important piece of equipment was his personal weapon, the flintlock musket known as Brown Bess. But he also had to carry a greatcoat, blanket, haversack, kettle, food bag, water canteens, and ammunition. On marches of around 25km (15 miles) a day, this added up to a heavy burden. Benjamin Harris, a foot soldier who served in the Peninsular campaign, wrote: "I am convinced that many of our infantry sank and died under the weight of their knapsacks alone."



Bayonet
The musket's fore stock is cut back to take a 43cm (17in) socket bayonet. A lug on the barrel fits into a notch in the bayonet head, turning the musket into a short pike.



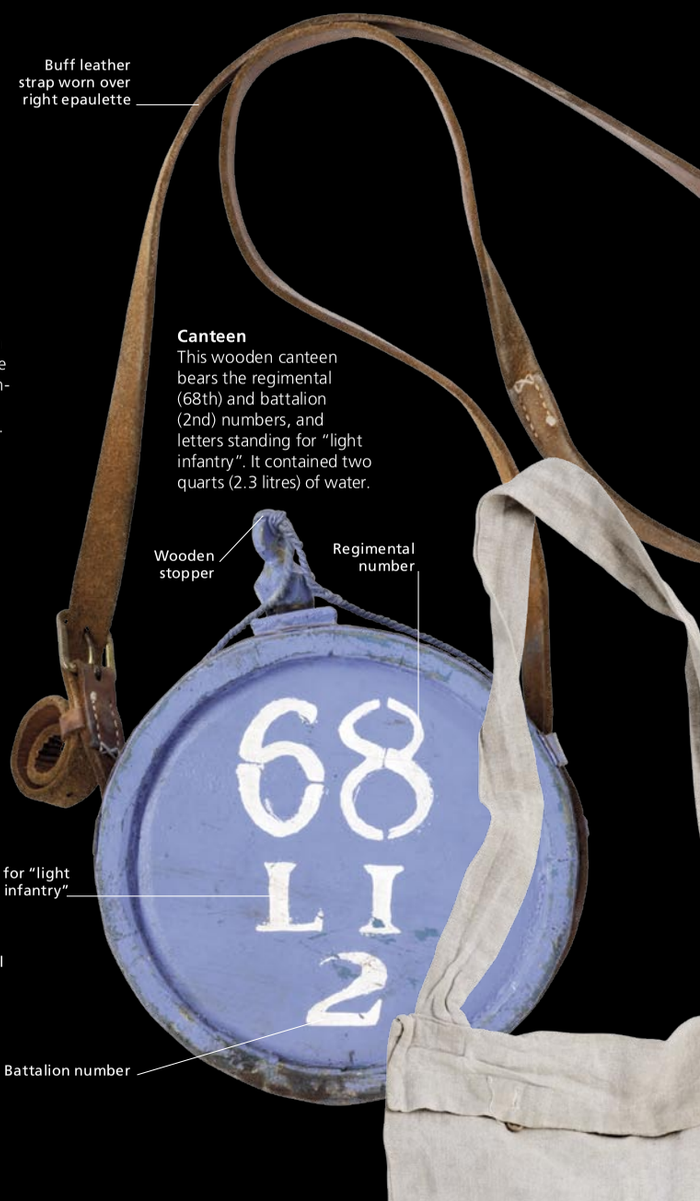
Ammunition bag
This bag could hold up to 60 cartridges, each of which contained powder and ball. The powder was used both as primer and charge, while the paper served as wadding to keep the ball in the barrel.





Ammunition
Firing the musket involved biting open the powder-end of the cartridge, sprinkling some powder into the flashpan as primer, then closing the flashpan and pouring the rest of the powder into the barrel, followed by the ball and the cartridge paper. A ramrod was then used to push the combination to the bottom of the barrel, where a touch-hole led to the primer, which was ignited by the flint striking the steel.





Canteen
This wooden canteen bears the regimental (68th) and battalion (2nd) numbers, and letters standing for "light infantry". It contained two quarts (2.3 litres) of water.